

next to each other when you are curating an exhibition...writing is often very similar to that act of curating and juxtaposing disparate elements."

In the afterword to the novel, Doshi credits the ideas of Carl Jung and there are indeed a number of Jungian passages throughout *The First House*, beginning as early as page 16, when a sudden swarm of cicadas visits the protagonist's neighbourhood. Doshi explains the concept of the 'imago'—the final, sexually mature life stage of an insect. But in the Jungian context (established by works such as *The Red Book*), 'imago' refers to a mental image one has of a loved one, often one that impedes our sense of their objective reality. Doshi applies the concept beautifully to (among other things) tease out parallels between two successive generations of sisters—the protagonist and Didi, and later the protagonist's two daughters.

"For me, Jung is a mystic and if you read *The Red Book*, it's a kind of prophecy, it's a descent into the underworld," says Doshi. "Jung thought of religion as a psychological mechanism, which got me thinking about my protagonist. She is not someone who expresses overt spirituality, but more a kind of mythic imagination. So these myths underpin the way she sees the world."

The First House is at once a superb novel of ideas and a finely observed character study. It is an accomplished follow-up to *Girl in White Cotton* and confirms Doshi's considerable gifts as a novelist. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

THE IDEA **OF ASIA**

ASIANISM AND THE FALL OF EMPIRE EXAMINES HOW ASIAN SOLIDARITY SHAPED INDIAN NATIONALISM—AND WHY ITS PROMISE PROVED DIFFICULT TO SUSTAIN AFTER INDEPENDENCE

The thesis of this book is that the idea of Asia made deep inroads into Indian thinking during the freedom struggle from colonial rule. The argument is: "Asianism was not external to but was in fact the foundation of both the cultural and political discourse of Indian national identity that anchored Indian anti colonialism and nationalism in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries."

The idea of Indian and Asian civilisational congruence consolidated as a response to racism and notions of British superiority. From the mid-nineteenth century, migration and travel from India to different parts of the British empire helped widen horizons and expand solidarities with others experiencing imperial racism.

Many elements of this process are well known. The triad of Mahatma Gandhi, Swami Vivekananda and Tagore all articulated ideas of civilisation that saw an overlap between Indian and Asian ideas and questioned the racist assumptions inherent in colonial rule. Japan's victory over Russia in 1905 had a euphoric impact on India as the victory of an Asiatic power over a European. Japan provided a refuge to many nationalists from India; and the Indian National Army mounted a military assault in concert with Japan on the British empire. The common thread running through such instances constitutes, in Mukherjee's words, a "discourse of civilisational Asianism".

The book consolidates these ideas into an aggregate of 'Indian Asianism' and seeks to demonstrate how "Asianism played a key role in the Indian independence movement".

How convincing is this argument? Undoubtedly, the idea of Asia and of Asian unity against western dominance was a prominent element in the Indian nationalist discourse. Just how much weightage to give to it is more problematic and on occasion the impression we get is that the book is overly generous in doing so. Secondly, the inherent contradictions in this 'Asian discourse' are not substantively addressed. As the process of decolonisation advanced, ideas of Asian unity, in fact, retreated quickly. Intra-Asian conflicts were the main reason—for instance the India-China breakdown from the late 1950s or the India-Indonesia frictions in the early 1960s. Nativist sentiments across Asia against Indian and other Asian migrants similarly demonstrated that the tactical unities forged during an anti-colonial struggle would face headwinds once there was no colonial power to resist. ■

—T.C.A. Raghavan

THOUGH PAN-ASIAN SOLIDARITY DURING THE COLONIAL YEARS WAS A FACT, ITS CONTRADICTIONS ARE NOT SUBSTANTIVELY ADDRESSED HERE

ASIANISM AND THE FALL OF EMPIRE: India's Road to Freedom
By Mithi Mukherjee
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